

THE NEAR MISSES

Over the past four decades, India and Pakistan have experienced several crises with nuclear overtones

1999 KARGIL WAR

Conflict in the Kargil region raised concerns about potential nuclear escalation



2001–2002 STANDOFF

Following the Dec. 13, 2001, attack on the Indian Parliament, both nations mobilised forces, leading to heightened nuclear alert levels

2019 PULWAMA-BALAKOT INCIDENT

A suicide bombing in Pulwama led to Indian airstrikes in Balakot, Pakistan, bringing the two countries close to open conflict

2025 PAHALGAM ATTACK

Had it not been halted after four days, the war, the US president said, would have escalated into a nuclear conflict

COMMAND AND CONTROL STRUCTURES

INDIA: NUCLEAR COMMAND AUTHORITY (NCA)

POLITICAL COUNCIL

↘ Chaired by the prime minister, the ultimate authority to give the go-ahead for nuclear strikes

EXECUTIVE COUNCIL

↘ Chaired by the National Security Advisor; provides inputs and executes directives

STRATEGIC FORCES COMMAND (SFC)

↘ Responsible for management and security of nuclear weapons

PAKISTAN: NATIONAL COMMAND AUTHORITY (NCA)

CHAIRMAN

↘ Prime Minister

MEMBERS

↘ Key military and civilian leaders

STRATEGIC PLANS DIVISION (SPD)

↘ Responsible for the management and security of nuclear weapons

India claims to have neutralised most incoming Pakistani munitions with minimal damage.

India struck back ferociously in the early hours of May 10 around 1.10 am, using among other missiles the BrahMos, its hypersonic cruise missile. It targeted eight air bases, including the one at Nur Khan in Chaklala between Rawalpindi, the general headquarters of the Pakistan army, and capital Islamabad. India's armed forces released photographs, showing the damage to vital infrastructure there. The Nur Khan base is also close to Pakistan's nuclear command and control headquarters. Pakistan prime minister Shehbaz Sharif later revealed that army chief General Asim Munir had called him up at 2.30 am and informed him of the attack on the air bases, including the one close to the capital. Meanwhile, sources disclose that the Indian navy, too, had by then positioned its strike fleet close to Karachi and had been alerted that orders to begin a blockade of Pakistan's ports were imminent.